

Pedro Magaña Sáenz

Agricultural and Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin-Madison

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Education

University of Wisconsin—Madison | Wisconsin, United States

Ph.D. in Agricultural and Applied Economics

May 2026 (expected)

M.S. in Agricultural and Applied Economics

2022

University of Michigan—Ann Arbor | Michigan, United States

M.S. in Applied Economics

2019

M.A. in Public Policy

2019

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) | Mexico City, Mexico

B.A. in Economics

2012

Fields of Interest

Development Economics; Agricultural Economics; Public Policy; Firms

Citizenship and U.S. work authorization

Mexican citizen with U.S. permanent residency

Working papers

Signed, Sealed, Delivered: Digital Receipts in the Ugandan Dairy Chain (Job Market Paper)

with David J. Henning

We provide causal evidence that digital receipts—SMS messages reporting milk deliveries—can improve accountability, delivery behavior, and product quality in agricultural markets with limited monitoring and weak enforcement mechanisms. In a randomized experiment with dairy cooperatives in western Uganda, we find that treated farmers, particularly those who self-deliver, are significantly more likely to deliver milk. This increase in delivery activity occurs without a change in average volumes delivered, suggesting a shift along the extensive margin. The intervention also improves milk quality: treated farmers deliver higher-quality (less diluted) milk. Among farmers who rely on transporters, digital receipts increase the likelihood of detecting discrepancies, switching baseline transporters, and reporting lower trust in intermediaries. These results show that the intervention works differently depending on whether information frictions are present: for self-deliverers, who already have full observability over their deliveries, impacts are concentrated on participation, while for transporter users, where observability is limited, impacts are concentrated on detecting discrepancies and moving away from dishonest transporters. By turning unobservable transactions into verifiable digital records, SMS receipts enhance transparency and make intermediary behavior more observable. Overall, our findings show how simple digital tools can reduce information frictions, shift farmer and intermediary behavior, and improve product quality in fragmented agricultural systems.

Work in progress

Banking Amidst Conflict: How Violence Shapes Financial Inclusion in Mexico

with Xiaofei Wang

Aligning Incentives through Digital Monitoring: Evidence from the Ugandan Dairy Sector

From Prayer to Progress: Religious Festivals and Development in Mexico

Research Grants

The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning and Erick Molina Perez</i>	2025
International Growth Centre (IGC) – Agri-SME Evidence Fund, £20,000 GBP <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2024
The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2023
J-PAL/CEGA – Digital Agricultural Innovations and Services (DAISI) Initiative , \$71,000 USD <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2023
International Growth Centre (IGC) – Small Project Facility, £20,000 GBP <i>Role: PI – with David J. Henning</i>	2022
Total external funding raised as PI: \$151,000 USD	

Honors and Awards

AAEA Travel Grant – Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA)	2025
Thomsen Distinguished Graduate Dissertator Fellowship (nominated) – University of Wisconsin—Madison	2024
AAE Dissertator Research Award – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$1,000 USD	2024
Barbara and Thomas Lyon Scholarship, \$4,000 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison.	2023
UW-Madison Travel Grant, \$1,500 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison	2022
Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award, University of Wisconsin—Madison	2021 – 2022
Rackham International Student Fellowship, \$10,000 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor.	2019
Annenberg Internship, \$7,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor	2017
Ford School Fellowship, \$2,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor	2017

Research Experience

Research Assistant, University of Wisconsin Madison, Wisconsin <i>Professors: Dr. Dustin Frye, Dr. Corbett Grainger, and Dr. Bradford Barham</i>	2021 – Present
Research Assistant, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>Professors: Dr. Eduardo Montero and Dr. Zach Y. Brown</i>	Spring 2020
Research Assistant, Center on Finance, Law and Policy, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>Professors: Michael Barr, J.D.; Dr. Antoinette Schoar, and Dr. Eldar Shafir</i>	Fall 2019
Research Assistant, Northwestern University Chicago, Illinois <i>Professors: Dr. Erika Deserranno and Dr. Gianmarco Leon-Ciliotta</i>	Summer 2019
Research Associate, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>Economic Growth Institute</i>	2018 – 2019
Research Assistant, University of Michigan Ann Arbor, Michigan <i>Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg</i>	2017 – 2018
Country Office Intern, Innovations for Poverty Action Lilongwe, Malawi <i>Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg</i>	Summer 2017
Research Coordinator, Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) Mexico City, Mexico <i>Professors: Dr. Enrique Seira and Dr. Joyce Sadka</i>	2011 – 2012

Professional Experience

Economic Analysis Coordinator, Ministry of Finance Mexico City, Mexico	2014 – 2016
Market Analyst, Laureate International Universities Mexico City, Mexico	2013 – 2014
Financial Analyst, Laureate International Universities Mexico City, Mexico	2012 – 2013
Parliamentary Advisor, Senate of Mexico Mexico City, Mexico	2010 – 2011

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, University of Wisconsin Madison, Wisconsin <i>AAE 474/ECON 474: Economic Problems of Developing Areas</i>	Fall 2025
<i>AAE 350: World Hunger and Malnutrition</i>	Spring 2022

Teaching Assistant, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan

PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation

Spring 2019

POLSCI 369: International Economic Relations

Fall 2018

PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation

Spring 2018

POLSCI 490: Game Theory and Formal Models

Fall 2017

Pre-Doctoral Publications

Magaña Sáenz, P.F. (2015). Behavioral Economics and Nudges Applied to Pawnshops. **Gaceta de Economía**, 34, 96-126. (Original in Spanish)

Talks

- 2025 AFE 2025 (University of Chicago), AAEA/WAEA Joint Annual Meeting, Juli Plant Grainger Public Workshop, Applied Economics Workshop (University of Wisconsin)
- 2024 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
- 2023 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
- 2022 Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)
- 2021 Development Lab (University of Wisconsin)

Affiliations

Graduate Research Fellow, Institute for Research on Poverty, University of Wisconsin

2025 – 2026

Other Information

Languages: Spanish (Native), English (Fluent)

Skills: Stata (Advanced), L^AT_EX (Advanced), Microsoft Office (Advanced), R (Intermediate), Python (Intermediate)

References

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